



Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Language & Communication

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/langcom

Black flight: Heterogeneous accounts of Mexican immigration in a diverse community

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ARTICLE INFO

Article history:
Available online xxx

Keywords:
Migration
Spatialization
Narrative
Othering
Community change

ABSTRACT

Once a predominantly White and Black community, since 1990 Marshall has experienced a 900% increase in residents of Mexican origin. This rapid demographic shift is particularly evident in changes to how commercial and residential spaces are owned and utilized. This article examines how residents of Marshall use spatiotemporal scales to imagine the economic and social trajectories of their town, and assign roles to different groups of people within these trajectories. We analyze how Marshall residents *spatialize* their accounts of community change by attending to two narratives that circulate simultaneously—the first is about community renewal following the arrival of Mexican residents; the second is about Black flight in response to perceived community disintegration. By tracing the production and circulation of these narratives, we move beyond an analysis of “othering” that presupposes a native “us” and immigrant “them.” Instead, we explore how Marshall’s diverse history of immigration, segregation, industrial development and decline produces heterogeneous, complex and shifting “others.”

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1. Introduction

Joyce, Doreena, Tiffany and I sit around the dining room table. Tiffany, looking down, fingers the tablecloth as Doreena explains her experiences of change in the old neighborhood. These changes ultimately prompted her to sell her house and move to a senior living community in a neighboring town. Her new home, where our conversation takes place, is a modest brick bungalow tucked away in a neatly manicured development.

Doreena: It’s gonna run it down with that many people—right, they put a lot of people in the house. I don’t care what neighborhood you go in, they live in a neighborhood, instead of 2 or 3 you’ll see a million people come. And they use both doors—I’ve seen it.

Interviewer: What do you mean? Front and back you mean?

Doreena: The front door and the back door and you can’t keep up with them [laughing]. You don’t know how many people are coming out like that, and you don’t know how many people are living in there, and you would like to know your neighbors—but you know

Tiffany looks up towards her grandmother.

Tiffany: But we *did*—Remember, we *did* know them when they moved in next to you—because I went to school with them, Guadalupe, and they took us trick-or-treating.

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Doreena, Joyce and Tiffany constitute three generations of an African American family that has lived in Marshall, a Mid-Atlantic town in the New Latino Diaspora, for the past 80 years. Doreena, the matriarch, was born in Marshall after her family moved north from Virginia in search of work in the area mills. Joyce, her ex-daughter-in-law, was married to Doreena's son and moved to the community to start her life with him. She has stayed in town, mainly because it is the only home her daughter Tiffany knows. Tiffany was born and raised in Marshall. She attended Marshall High School, and at the time of this conversation she was home for the summer before entering her sophomore year of college in Chicago. As the passage above suggests, members of the different generations position themselves distinctly with respect to the Mexican immigrants who have come to Marshall over the past 2 decades.

Doreena thinks of the Mexican immigrants in Marshall in terms of the changes they have brought to her old neighborhood—how they “run it down,” how she no longer knew how many people were living next to her, how she no longer knew her neighbors. Thus, she communicates her sense of dislocation. But her granddaughter Tiffany contests this representation. She reminds Doreena that she “did know them” and that in fact their families had social connections through trick-or-treating and attending school together. Doreena and Tiffany tell conflicting stories about the arrival of Mexican immigrants in Marshall. These stories illustrate the complex nature of “othering” in Marshall. “Othering” is a process in which self and other are mutually constituted as different and hierarchically organized (Crang, 1998) using essentialized dichotomies (Hinton, 2002). Othering takes place at multiple scales, including both temporal and spatial (Fabian, 1983), and the resulting evaluations and hierarchies often shift over time. In Marshall, diverse histories of immigration, segregation, industrial development and decline make processes of “othering” more complicated than the typical story of homogeneous hosts othering newcomers.

Once a predominantly White and Black community, since 1990 Marshall has experienced a 900% increase in residents of Mexican origin. This rapid demographic shift is evident throughout the community—but it is particularly felt in changes of ownership and use of both commercial and residential space. In this article, we examine how residents of Marshall imagine the economic and social trajectories of their town, paying particular attention to the roles assigned to different groups of people within these trajectories. We focus on how Marshall residents use space to tell stories about the transformations in their town. We examine how people explain the past, present and future of Marshall by deploying ideologies about commercial and residential space to help them understand various groups in their changing community. Specifically we look at narratives related to Marshall's nostalgic past (Cavanaugh, 2004), periods of economic decline, and the rapid emergence of the Mexican community. Through these narratives our interlocutors deploy differing spatiotemporal scales, and heterogeneously position the relationship between themselves, Mexican immigrants, and a changing community.

The stories of a changing Marshall draw on space and time to interpret social life (Carr and Lempert, 2016), making comparisons between then-and-now as well as us-and-them (Gal, 2016). Through these stories, spaces become invested with social meaning, a process De Fina (2009) terms *spacialization*. We examine how Marshall residents spacialize their accounts of community change, creating and presupposing “networks of association between representation, material conditions of existence and social relations” (p. 112) within the community. We understand processes of *spacialization* to be relational, both situated in and accomplished through the retelling of town trajectories. Time and space are not only aspects of the settings in which action occurs, but they are also interdiscursively produced, socially positioned forms of action (Blommaert, 2015; De Genova and Ramos-Zayas, 2003) that help produce ideologies that contribute to the trajectories of the community and its residents.

We attend to processes of *spacialization* by exploring two narratives that circulate simultaneously—the first is about community renewal that followed the arrival of Mexican residents; the second is about Black flight in response to perceived community disintegration. The politics of migration often involve racialized, nativist boundaries that produce an immigrant “other” (Chavez, 2013; De Genova and Ramos-Zayas, 2003). But this account of boundary formulation does not suffice to explain the more complex discursive dynamics of inclusion, exclusion and other positionings that happen in Marshall. In this article, we complicate the relationships between “immigrants” and “hosts” by describing a multiracial context in which residents occupy and assign positions beyond these two. As immigrants arrive, processes of inclusion and exclusion take place on multiple axes and involve heterogeneous assemblages of resources. “Othering” presupposes an “us” and a “them” (Gumperz, 1982), but in Marshall there are several different types of “them.”

Residents' *spacialized* accounts of Marshall narrate community transformation, describing neighborhoods and commercial areas as the town has experienced rapid demographic change. These spaces are some of the first places where community shifts become visible. As new businesses serving Mexican clientele open in Marshall's commercial areas, and as long time residents move out and make way for immigrant families, those who remain find themselves confronted with a community they thought they knew, but which now feels foreign to them. For some, these shifts are positive signs of revitalization and growth, while for others the changes feel alienating. Different accounts of these changes are given along racial and generational lines. Entangled in the history of Mexican migration are shifts in the local housing market, the opening of malls leading to the decimation of local commerce, potentially prejudicial housing ordinances and community policing practices, and the increasing suburbanization of the surrounding area. In this context, accounts of space reflect more than one type of contestation.

We trace how Marshall residents use both space and time to narrate imagined town trajectories and position themselves with respect to the demographic changes brought by immigration. We examine residents' accounts of residential and commercial space, analyzing how these renderings help residents make sense of their community and envision the town's future. Their accounts of community change are heterogeneous and tend to vary with the race of the narrator. Thus

spacialization connects with longstanding histories of racialization and race relations in the community, informing often-divergent narratives of the town's past, present and future, and illustrating the heterogeneous construction of the "other" in Marshall.

2. Heterogeneous "othering" in the New Latino Diaspora

Drawing on [Latour's \(2005\)](#) actor-network theory, we understand social identification and "othering" to be processes contingent on heterogeneous resources drawn from different spatial and temporal scales. We can follow the actors and objects in any given network to understand the resources which "transform, translate, distort and modify" meaning (p. 39). We pay close attention to the ways in which Marshall residents represent historical, contemporary and future spaces within their community. We follow the actors, both human and nonhuman, in order to locate the resources which converge to make possible the complex processes of "othering" and racialization that take place in Marshall. We conceive of scale, following [Blommaert \(2007\)](#), as a vertical, hierarchical, power-laden ordering of social space-time, and recognize that all processes in the human world draw on resources from across scales ([Carr and Lempert, 2016](#); [Lemke, 2000](#)). Our analyses of "othering" describe the production of social hierarchies. "Othering" certainly takes place, and it is crucial to describe how people mobilize resources to produce differential access to symbolic and material effects. Traditional accounts of "othering" fail to capture the production of essentialized groups, and fail to recognize the heterogeneous positions and outcomes involved in this production. In our account we describe the heterogeneity involved in the production of others.

In addition to actor-network theory, we also rely on a different scalar approach involving the cross-event theories of language to understand how social positioning occurs across time ([Agha and Wortham, 2005](#); [Wortham, 2006](#); [Agha, 2007](#); [Silverstein, 2013](#)). Speech chains, or trajectories of linked events, are the units through which processes of social identification, group formation and cultural change occur ([Agha and Wortham, 2005](#)). Across chains of events, certain signs become enregistered as durably associated with specific groups of people and places. This takes place as heterogeneous resources from relevant networks are assembled in ways that make more rigid trajectories of events possible. In Marshall, more than one type of rigid trajectory emerges, as members of different groups position themselves and others distinctly.

Racialization and processes of "othering" depend on the convergence of heterogeneous resources at various scales ([Omi and Winant, 2014](#)) and articulations of the "other" in political, economic and material contexts ([Berg et al., 2015](#)). Racialized politics, and the racial formations from which they derive, are creative practices, depending on shifting naturalizations and constructions of space, place and identity ([De Genova and Ramos-Zayas, 2003](#); [Durrheim and Dixon, 2001](#); [McCann, 1999](#)). Social identification and "othering," often along racial lines, are inherently relational processes operating in tandem ([M'charek, 2013](#)). They are not fixed or stable, but instead rely on the (re)assemblage of heterogeneous resources, both affective and material, to make boundaries more or less durable. The rapid demographic change in Marshall involves processes of "othering" beyond the familiar story in which a homogeneous group of longstanding residents "others" immigrants. Longstanding residents identify themselves as members of various groups, both demographically and generationally, and "othering" occurs in more than one way and it is thus not unidirectional.

2.1. Data and methodology

As an area of the country in which Latinos have not historically resided, Marshall is considered a New Latino Diaspora (henceforth NLD) town ([Murillo and Villenas, 1997](#); [Suro and Singer, 2002](#); [Wortham et al., 2009](#)). In 2009 Wortham et al. argued that in this NLD community both immigrants and longstanding residents had more flexibility in how they identify one another, although this flexibility may be waning as the Mexican migrant population becomes more settled. In Marshall, Mexicans are often positioned by White residents both as hard working, family oriented "model minorities" and as naive, passive and easily victimized ([Wortham et al., 2009, 2011](#)). Both Mexican and White residents also sometimes represent Blacks as violent and unkind towards Mexicans, a characterization that Black residents contest ([Wortham et al., 2011](#)). We find similarly divergent accounts of Marshall's trajectory and the roles of various groups, as Mexican immigrants arrive and the uses of space in town shift.

This article draws from data collected over 10 years of ethnographic work in Marshall. Since 2005, our research team has conducted observations and interviews in schools across the Marshall School District, in churches, non-profit organizations, businesses, community centers, and participants' homes. These data provide information about the town, the school district, the history of Latino migration and how narratives about immigrants circulate in Marshall. We also draw on archival analyses of newspaper articles, political speeches, council meeting records, and social media postings. Since July of 2014, we have conducted targeted interviews with 14 longstanding Black community members in order to learn more about how they are making sense of their changing community. Interviews were conducted both individually and in groups, mostly in the form of extended conversations between Marshall residents and the interviewer. These conversations ranged from 40 min to over an hour and a half.

3. History of Marshall

Marshall, a suburb in a major East Coast metropolitan area, has a population of about 35,000 people, which today is almost equally divided between Latino, Black and White residents. In 1990 Marshall had about 100 Mexican residents, but this grew

to 2000 in 2000, and over 8000 in 2010 (U. S. Census Bureau, 2015). As mentioned above, in New Latino Diaspora towns, attitudes and ideologies are often more elastic than in areas of historic Latino presence, allowing Latinos and longstanding residents some flexibility in how they imagine themselves and how they racialize others (Wortham et al., 2009). But there are questions as to how long that elasticity will last, as the migrant population becomes more settled (Hamann et al., 2015). Exploring how various residents imagine the past, present and future trajectories of Marshall can help illuminate the ways in which some forms of “othering” may become rigid over time, while others may remain flexible.

Latino migration to Marshall is part of a long history of people moving into and through the area. Originally settled by people of English origin at the turn of the 19th century, Marshall grew rapidly and after the Civil War became an industrial, retail, banking and government hub. In the mid 1800s, Irish immigrants arrived to work on the railroads. The railroads opened up infrastructure for new industry, including the construction of many mills. Following the Great Migration at the end of the 19th century, black residents began arriving from the South in search of factory work. This is when Doreena’s parents moved to the area in order to escape lives as sharecroppers in Virginia. Doreena, whose conversation with her granddaughter and daughter-in-law appear above, is a lifelong Marshall resident, a product of early African American migration to the community. The early 1900s also saw a significant influx of Italian immigrants to Marshall, originally migrating as stonemasons and other tradesmen. The town became a hub of culture, commerce and industry, with railroads and then highways converging there. It was home to multiple department stores, churches, and theaters. More Blacks and Italians came in the decades after World War II because of the booming local industry of textile mills, ice-houses, foundries, and lumber-yards. Smaller numbers of Puerto Rican, Asian and Caribbean newcomers settled in Marshall for short periods of time in the second half of the 20th century, but most of them have since left the area. The growth of the Mexican population in Marshall is more dramatic than previous migrations, both in terms of the quantities of people who have arrived over a relatively short period of time, and in the fact that they have remained in town and are thus having a lasting impact.

Prior to the recent Mexican migration, Marshall was a predominantly White and Black community. Both communities were far from homogeneous. White residents were comprised predominately of Italian and Irish origin residents. These two groups most often lived, worshiped, and socialized separately, and it was not until the 1950s that Italian residents participated regularly in town governance. The Black community in Marshall is comprised both of long standing residents from multi-generational Marshall families and of more recent arrivals from the nearby city. While the longstanding residents are generally educated middle class homeowners, the newer arrivals tend to be poorer and less well educated. Despite the heterogeneity within the White and Black communities, the division between Whites and Blacks in Marshall was nonetheless clear. Whites traditionally lived in the west and east ends of the community, with Black residents occupying the town center and parts of the near west end. As more Black residents moved into the community after World War II, White residents moved to the edges of the west end, eventually moving into the suburbs of East and West Marshall. These communities, while not part of the town itself, are in the same school district. Today, between East Marshall, West Marshall, and Marshall proper there exists a significant racial and socioeconomic divide. East and West Marshall are wealthier and whiter than the town itself, while the center of Marshall is home to both Black and Mexican residents. The economic and migration histories of Marshall shape how Marshall residents narrate the past, present and future of the community and how they position Mexican immigrants. White and Black narratives of the town’s trajectory are *spacialized* in ways that overlap but also diverge. Through their heterogeneous uses of space and time, residents construct notions of belonging, displacement, decline and revitalization within the community.

4. Narratives of Marshall’s trajectory

4.1. White residents

From the 1960s through the 1980s, Marshall suffered a period of extensive economic decline that involved both decreasing household incomes and loss of population. This historical trend is connected to larger patterns of deindustrialization and suburbanization in the United States (Bluestone and Harrison, 1982). The decline in Marshall resulted in significant part from the construction of two nearby malls, a major interstate that bypassed the town center, the steady elimination of mill jobs that once sustained the town’s middle class, and the closure of a nearby state hospital. As jobs disappeared, residents no longer had disposable income to spend in the stores along Main Street, and what shopping they did took place at the mall where parking was ample and prices were lower. As a result, the once thriving commercial area of downtown Marshall, became obsolete and many storefronts were boarded up. While this history of economic decline can be analyzed empirically, citing store closings and household incomes, Marshall residents imagine the past in ways that do not strictly correspond with such a representation.

How Marshall residents imagine the economic and social trajectories of the town, and the roles they assign to different groups within these trajectories, varies based on ethnicity and generation. As mentioned earlier, the White community in Marshall is far from homogenous—it tends to be divided between Italian and Irish residents, who have distinct histories. There are also generational divides between White residents who are themselves immigrants, and those of subsequent generations. Nonetheless, when discussing transformations in the use of space in Marshall, there are noticeable similarities in the ways White residents of varying backgrounds narrate the history of the town, its future trajectory as a community, and the roles they assign to themselves and other residents.

4.2. Marshall “before”

Our White interlocutors consistently describe Marshall's distant past nostalgically, constructing a “dialectic between the past and the present” which relies on both temporalities and embeds speakers within specific local and national moments (Cavanaugh, 2004). They *spacialize* the town in ways that express a sense of community and connectedness that defines Marshall “before.” For these interlocutors, “before” means before the perceived economic decline of the community that began in the 1960s when the nearby mall was built and the town experienced substantial White flight. Henry, for example, grew up in an Italian family and moved from Brooklyn to Marshall as a young child. He describes Marshall as a community where everybody knew everybody, and the experiences of his childhood were defined by the various spaces that brought the residents of Marshall together:

“I would say growing up in Marshall, growing up going to the movie theaters, having 5 movie theaters, bowling alleys, we had the different clubs that we went to. We had the baseball team. There was Friday night football, there was baseball in the park. It was a place everybody would go. The swings, the zoo. The zoo is for free it didn't cost anything to go to the zoo. And everybody knew everybody. The policeman. The one block that I lived on, there were five or six police officers lived on the one block.”

In this rendering, Henry focuses on his experiences at local parks, in the theaters, and in his neighborhood to characterize the Marshall community as connected and vibrant. Such narratives filled with nostalgia were common among White residents, regardless of their ethnic background. As a local teacher recalled about Marshall, “it used to be a great place to live with quiet streets, with families, and it was clean and safe.” Another resident explained how the town began with the Italian, Irish, and some Polish families who were “the kind of people who scrub their front steps” and had street fairs. In these historical narratives, the speakers describe the spaces in town in order to characterize both how the community was and the types of people who lived there—hardworking (“they scrub their front steps”), industrious, law abiding, and family oriented. What is particularly striking in White narrators' stories of Marshall “before” is the consistent historical erasure (Irvine and Gal, 2009) of the Black community, which was already established in Marshall by the early 1900s. This erasure is important because it informs White residents' explanations of the community's decline. Rendering Marshall as town of Italian, Irish and some Polish families helps to establish types of people who were able to make Marshall “clean and safe.”

Some of our Italian interlocutors describe the struggle they and their families faced as immigrants, when they were treated as racialized “others.” Marco, a long time resident in his seventies, described his grandfather's experiences, and those of early Italian residents generally, by comparing the treatment of Italians to the treatment of Black people during slavery:

“Right now the black people say ‘ohh, they used to treat us as slaves’ The Italian people were the same thing, they didn't treat them right at all. I remember my grandfather used to say every time he used to come into Marshall to go to the stores to buy stuff they used to stone him, and they throw stones at him and everything else.”

Marco goes on to explain that, by the 1950s, Italians were no longer treated poorly because they were achieving success—in his words, “they started joining all the police force and the mayor's office,” and had control over half of Marshall. This description of the early treatment of Italian residents, and comparisons to Black slavery, are significant because they establish a social type: “hard-working.” White migrants who were able to succeed despite challenges and discrimination—apparently in contrast to a Black “other.” As we will show next, this historical narrative allows for White Italian residents to simultaneously see themselves as similar to the new Mexican migrants and position Black residents as the “other” who are culpable for the decline of the community.

4.3. Area decline

For our White interlocutors, changes in the community result from two primary causes: economic decline resulting from mill closures and the opening of area malls in the 1960s, which made the commercial area of Marshall irrelevant, and an influx of new Black residents that happened around the same time. The opening of malls and the closing of the mills broke the communal ties that held the town together, and people began to leave. As Henry explains:

“If you want to meet somebody [today], the only time you meet them may be at the shopping center. Or maybe at the mall. And then they're not gonna stay there and talk because they're busy. They parked their car, they had a hard time getting into the shopping center. They get in there they want to shop, get home before the traffic gets bad. You know everything is a movement. In Marshall, when people shopped they would go to the corner store. There weren't any big shopping centers. I think that's what changed Marshall—The people started moving out of town. For what reason, I can only think, I think the government that we had, the leaders of our community in the 50s I think were responsible for not keeping Marshall together.”

In Henry's account, the mall makes redundant the previously central space of Main Street and shifts the patterns of social life in the community. Whereas before people would walk down the street to the corner store and get to know one another, after the malls opened people become “busy” and “want to get home before traffic gets bad.” Following national trends towards suburbanization, when the malls opened many White families who had once lived in downtown Marshall began to move into wealthier suburban areas. Marco describes how the arrival of Black residents led to the departure of White Italians:

"Nobody lives in Marshall anymore—It used to be a very nice place and then a lot of people come from the south and when one somebody buy a house colored people used to buy a house the next year you sell the house, the black people coming in, the Italian people they go out."

Another town resident explained that many of the "original" families moved out, leaving Marshall mostly Black, claiming that the White families "noticed the influx, so they moved away. That's when the complexion of the town really changed." Our interlocutor's use of the word "complexion" labels the changes in Marshall as simultaneously economic and racial. In these narratives, the two are inextricably linked. Her representation of the "original" families as White again reinforces the erasure of early Black residents. White flight in these stories is justified by a perception of Black arrival. According to many White residents, this story of population shift co-occurs with an increase in Section 8 (public) housing and the emergence of slumlords. As one White school teacher noted:

"Somewhere along the line in the 1960s or 70s landlords began to buy up houses, they were allowed to subdivide them and rent them out. They're looking to make money instead of selling them to families. Five to six men in town started buying up property and making a lot of money off of Section 8 housing."

Another White resident explained that there was, "a lot of Section 8 housing. At one point there were a lot of slumlords." Marshall in decline is also frequently described as the "dumping ground" of the county, where the racialized poor and destitute come because of the available housing stock. These representations of the economic and social trajectory of Marshall use both the closure of commercial spaces and changes in neighborhood makeup—from White to Black, and owner-occupied to Section 8 housing—to narrate the devastation of the community. But in the White accounts this devastation reverses when Mexican migrants begin to settle.

4.4. Narratives of spatial revitalization

According to the narratives of our White interlocutors, after suffering many years of community decline, Mexican immigrants started arriving in Marshall. As a local priest explains, "it was small, but almost overnight it just exploded so we have a lot of Mexican families who are here." While White interlocutors initially expressed some concern over the fact that early Mexican migrants were predominantly men, coming on their own to work and send money home, as the years passed more and more intact Mexican families came to the community. An area educator describes this progression:

"One thing is, it is revitalizing the areas because families are moving in. Yes, you have these, well, you have some unaccompanied minors who get in to groups of men, and this and that, and you do have groups of men living together and there are sociological problems with that, but a lot of it is families coming and bringing stability and revitalizing the neighborhoods, and there are various Mexican business opening up."

These new community residents are now described as a "revitalizing" force by longstanding White residents, and are often compared favorably to earlier Italian migrants. Marco is a landlord and has a number of Mexican tenants. He notes that they always pay their rent on time, and that they "look like the Italian people too because they're good workers" who will themselves own many of the businesses in 25 years because "when you put them to work, they work." We heard this favorable characterization of Mexicans frequently. But it was often paired with an equally unfavorable characterization of Black residents. White narrators often drew on ideologies of space in order to position Mexicans as a more desirable town resident, whose experiences and orientations are similar to earlier White immigrants and different from Black community members. As one interlocutor describes, "the Mexicans who came here work ... they're not sitting on a stoop drinking beer with a Cadillac in the driveway; they send money home," because family is important to them. This comment positions Mexicans as hard workers who care about their families, as opposed to people who sit on stoops drinking beer next to their Cadillacs. While the speaker does not directly say she is comparing Mexican residents to Black residents, her invoking of a "Cadillac" calls upon a common indexical of Blackness (see "welfare Cadillacs," [Delgado and Gordon, 2002](#)). To this she attaches an image of vagrancy and an unwillingness to work. Other White residents make the comparison more directly. Marco, after his initial comparison of Mexicans to Italians, went on to say:

"they (Mexicans) want to better themselves, you can see it, it's just like the Italian people the Italian people when they come from Italy they just work like slaves because they want to better themselves; that's what it looks like the Mexicans are, but the Black people they just want everything for free. Welfare, welfare, welfare."

It is critical to see in these narratives how the incorporation of Mexican migrants into the community presupposes the "othering" of Black residents. By assigning Mexican residents a role in the community similar to that of previous White migrants, they become harbingers of positive change and development, positioned in opposition to Black residents who index community decline.

Various White residents describe how Mexican immigration has brought back a sense of "togetherness" the town once possessed and has put Marshall back on the "upward trajectory" it once occupied. One younger man, who only recently moved back to downtown Marshall, talked about how "those Mexicans are giving me the neighborhood I am missing" because "they are just so giving, in a nice way"—they help him if his car battery dies or he gets locked out of his house. An

older woman, who is a member of the local Catholic Church, describes her parish since Mexican arrival: “You have the Irish and the Mexican and the Italian and everyone gets along with one another.” Another woman, Mary explains that:

“I think it’s on an upward trajectory. I think it’s on an upward trajectory. I do think the revitalization because truthfully I don’t think the revitalization actually took hold until you started seeing more of the places, umm businesses moving in and I think it is when many of the Mexican restaurants started up and many of those Mexican business—I’ve driven through downtown on Saturday nights on come down on Main St. and gone out and everything else and it’s alive. I mean, there is stuff going on, you can hear the music, you can hear everybody; people are out on the street and things like that. Fifteen years ago I could tell you I would have been more afraid to drive through Marshall.”

This narrative of the town’s future, the “upward trajectory” of Marshall, is widely shared by White residents. It depends on a very specific understanding of Marshall’s history and the actors, both social and material, involved in that history. White Marshall residents invoke images of residential and commercial space—the neighborhoods, the streets, restaurants and stores—both to explain how the town was “before,” what it was like during periods of economic decline, and to provide evidence of its renewal.

As a result of historical White flight, most long standing White residents do not live in the center of Marshall anymore. Thus, while they notice changes along Main street in terms of business development, their residential communities have been largely unaffected by Mexican migration. This is not the case for Marshall’s Black residents, whose experiences of Mexican migration involve drastic changes in the composition of their neighborhoods in addition to shifts in the businesses along Main Street. This differential impact of migration to the community is acknowledged by some White residents, one of whom noted that the “old Marshallites,” who are Black, feel that property values are going down, which is analogous to what happened when the Black community moved into Marshall. The priest at the local Irish Catholic church explained that the Mexicans are moving into houses that were bought up by “guys who say ‘we pay cash for houses,’” the houses are then subdivided and rented out to Mexican families, and this “tends to happen in African American neighborhoods.” This awareness of how migration might be impacting Black residents does not alter the overall representation of the promise Mexicans bring to Marshall’s future.

There are some similarities between the ways White and Black residents narrate the trajectory of the town—most significantly their nostalgic renderings of Marshall’s past. But, as we will show next, there are also key differences in the stories each group tells, particularly with respect to the causes of economic decline in the community and the impact of Mexican migration.

4.5. Black residents

The Black community members we interviewed in Marshall are all longstanding residents, some of whom come from multi-generational Marshall families. They are educated professionals, part of what was once a vibrant Black middle class in the community. We do not claim that their accounts reflect all Black narratives of community change in Marshall, but rather those of longstanding Black residents who have deep roots in the town. Unlike White residents who circulated narratives of revitalization in Marshall as a result of Mexican migration, our Black interlocutors spoke of the emergence of “Black flight” from the community whereby longstanding Black residents leave as a result of feeling excluded from a changing Marshall. Black residents relied on various spatiotemporal scales to tell this story of exclusion. Like White interlocutors, these Black residents presented a nostalgic imaginary of Marshall “before.” For these community members, however, “before” meant something distinct than we described for the White narratives. The narratives differed in scale for our Black interlocutors for whom “before” was not a time before the economic decline and White flight in the 1960s–1980s. Instead, it refers to a time before the arrival of Mexican immigrants. Whether the speakers were in their 20s or their 80s, our Black interlocutors construed “before” as a time of economic success and communal good will. They, like their White counterparts, also characterized spaces in the community—stores, neighborhoods, houses—to narrate this time by utilizing intersecting spatial and temporal scales.

4.6. Marshall “before”

Our Black interlocutors highlighted the sense of family and community they felt in town “before.” They also focused on the importance of home ownership and residential stability to the community. Contrary to many accounts offered by White residents, our Black interlocutors described their own community as hard working and family oriented, comparing the work ethic of Black Marshall residents to that of early Italians. Black community members’ characterizations of Marshall “before” are strikingly similar to those of White residents. For example, Officer Smith, a local Police officer, described his family’s arrival in town:

“My father got a job at the Iron and Steel Company. He started working there. We were able to save up money and between my father and my uncle, they bought a house together on Moore Street—My uncle and his family lived on the 1st floor and my father and my mother and my brothers and I we lived on the 2nd floor. We shared the house together with the kitchen and the bathroom and we managed to make it work. And when my father was able to save up enough money between working in the steel mill and my mother doing day’s work and working little part-time jobs as the cashier at one of the local restaurants

here in town and they were able to save up enough money to buy their own home. I think the majority of people owned their homes, you know. I know my mum and dad, my uncles, a lot of my friends you know they owned their homes, just about everybody on Moore Street. There wasn't a lot of rentals back then. It was home ownership. And everybody was interested in buying; that was the dream, to own your home."

Officer Smith describes a Marshall in which families worked together in order to achieve upward mobility, and particularly home ownership. Home ownership indexes community success in this narrative, and Officer Smith emphasizes that, "the majority of people owned their homes." This establishes a marked distinction between Marshall "before" and Marshall now, as will be discussed in the next section. The dream of home ownership also positions this Black community within a larger discourse of community development and the "American dream." Later in the conversation, Officer Smith elaborates his account of Marshall as a "booming town":

"Back in the day it was a booming town. The weekends were—everybody looked forward to the weekends. Friday night, Saturday, we went downtown, downtown Marshall—That was the thing back in the day you know. We liked to dress up a little bit, put on nice clothes, go down Main Street with mom, do some shopping ... You could shop, you could buy almost anything."

In his desire to communicate the "booming" nature of Marshall, Officer Smith refers repeatedly to the vibrancy of the commercial space and to how it was a locus of fulfilling community life. It was where people went on the weekends. It was what families got dressed up for. He later explains that walking down Main Street was one of the ways in which community members came to know one another—they would encounter each other at the "little corner grocery stores" where they could get eggs, milk, and butter, and he describes how "you can go right to the store you know down the street and back then I guess everybody you know got along." This account is strikingly similar to Henry's description cited above. Both narrators describe public spaces in ways that demonstrate community togetherness "before." In his representations of the past, Officer Smith describes how Italian and Black communities both had pride in their heritage and a desire to come to Marshall to start new lives. He reiterates the importance of homeownership to community pride:

"Well, like I said, back in the day you know we had a lot of the communities—the east end was predominantly Italian and black you know. They were homeowners. It was a proud community. The Italians were proud of their heritage. And of course you know the Black community we had our heritage. We were proud people you know. A lot of us came up here from down south and started a new life."

While Officer Smith clearly delineates between the Black and Italian communities, he notes that they lived together and shared common core values. In his rendering of Marshall's past, he does not position White Italians as distant social others. This is different from many of the White residents' tellings, in which Black community members are positioned as new arrivals who fundamentally alter the social and economic trajectory of the town. Doreena, Joyce and Tiffany co-construct a similar nostalgic account of a racially mixed community when they discuss the commercial space that used to exist on Main Street:

Doreena: They had Black, Black and White people were on Main Street

Tiffany: Yeah, my hairdresser used to be there and it's not there anymore

Doreena: yeah, all of the—the mixed, it was mixed community on Main Street

Joyce: It was mixed but it was, it was Italians

Doreena: Italians

Tiffany: Yeah

Doreena: Italians, Blacks

Joyce: I don't know if it was the Black people were the owners or more like the hairdressers in the barber shops

Doreena: Right, right, yeah, and they, what the—some of them had

Joyce: and worked at the nail salons

Doreena: a lot of them had businesses, they had business they used to have second hand stores, uh, and different shops, up there you know, yeah, a lot of them moved on, a lot of them people moved on

It is interesting to note that, while the three women co-construct a Marshall from "before" by describing the space of Main Street as the locus of their memories, it is not possible that these three women are actually speaking of the same time in Marshall's history. Doreena is in her 80s and was born in the community; Joyce is in her 40s; and Tiffany is only 20. So their "before" is not a shared moment in time, instead, three temporal scales are intersecting with different imaginary spaces in order to co-construct a Marshall "before" that catered to the needs of the Black community. When Tiffany was born, Mexican migration had already begun, as had significant economic decline. But the three generations of the family nonetheless co-create a shared nostalgic imaginary of Marshall, in which Main Street was filled with shops that catered to Black residents, and in which Italian and Black residents lived together. They co-locate themselves with Italians, in a time and space before the people and the stores had "moved on." Doreena goes on to explain that, in this time "before," Main Street was "wonderful, it was like, it was wonderful. Stores was down in Marshall, you could go to stores from one end of Main Street all the way down." In contrast, "now there's no businesses down there." This temporal disjunction between then and now—with "then" signifying sometime before the current moment of Mexican migration, occurs over and over again in Black community members' accounts of Marshall.

Jamar and Harrison are both African American community organizers and educators in their early 30s. Both grew up in Marshall, left to attend college, and then returned to work in the community. Although their accounts of Marshall describe different eras than those narrated by Officer Smith and Doreena, their descriptions of space in Marshall contribute to positive constructions of the town's past. Jamar explains how he lived in a quiet neighborhood on the West End of town, and at "8 AM all the kids came out on the block, and we played around in the parking lot, the church parking lot all day. Come and get something to eat, go back out and play." Harrison describes a similar feeling in the community:

"Growing up, in my opinion it was a small town feel. All the families were connected, you know you had your east end you had your west end, but it was still a small town—you know you had a lot of Black families, you had a lot of Caucasian families, you also had your Indian, Asian and Hispanic families, but to how it's shifted today, things changed a lot today. Um, you know, it did seem a little bit more prosperous, a lot more families, a lot more working families."

Just as Henry, our White Italian interlocutor, described the connectedness of the families in Marshall "before," so do Harrison and Jamar. This "small town feel" and relative prosperity is similar across historical accounts of the community, from both Whites and Blacks. But the actual era Jamar and Harrison are describing—their childhoods in Marshall during the late 1980s and early 1990s—is an era construed by White residents as a period of extreme economic decline and loss. It is a time when another White resident, Maria, explained that she was "afraid to drive through Marshall." Both Whites and Blacks describe a positive time "before," but they differentially construct when that moment in the town's history occurred.

4.7. White flight: from home ownership to rental properties

The story of White people leaving Marshall, beginning in the 1960s, is told by both White and Black narrators. But their accounts differ significantly. White residents describe White flight as a result of Black migration into Marshall and the concurrent economic decline. Black community members do not present White flight as the cause of economic decline. The town still felt both intact and economically prosperous to Black residents during the period of White flight. But White flight did open up housing stock that turned from owner-occupied to rental, and Mexicans moved into those rentals. According to Black narrators, this movement from an ownership community to a rental community was the cause of the decline. When White residents left the downtown area many did not sell their homes to other families, but rather maintained them as rental properties or sold them to landlords who would subdivide the houses into apartments. Thus, for Black Marshall residents, White flight brings a critical transition in Marshall from an ownership community to a rental community. Both White and Black residents cite White flight as a juncture in the town's history, but they heterogeneously position its impact. Home ownership meant prosperity, success, and stability for the community, while rental properties promote transience and damage the sense of togetherness Black residents of Marshall felt "before." Rentals also open up a significant amount of inexpensive housing stock, which ultimately enables Mexican migrants (and other new residents) to move into Marshall. Joyce explains her experience of this transition:

"Um, it's just when you have a lot of transient, a population coming in, that it becomes hard. Like I said, I don't know whether that's Mexicans, or whether it's just transient. Or maybe it's, you know, maybe I'm just seeing a lot of people who aren't taking care of their properties, taking care, because they're poor people. It's just like my house, and I think, when I, my house, I mean it's, it's gone down in value from when I first moved into it."

Michelle describes similar concerns and directly connects White flight with Mexican arrivals:

"I'd say that there were a lot of whites moving out. More Mexicans moving in, and it's unfortunate too because I feel like with the Mexicans moving in a lot of them probably were not supposed to be here so that gave land lords more of an opportunity to take full advantage of their living situations."

Despite the fact that White flight began in the 1960s and Mexican arrival did not happen until the 1990s, both Joyce and Michelle see them as linked. The transition from an ownership community to a rental community also marks changes in both the social and economic realities for Black homeowners. Many interlocutors discussed their falling home values as the neighborhood transitioned. For those Black residents whose most substantial asset is their house, this drop in value created significant challenges. Beyond the economic impact of this transition, long term Black residents describe a social impact, in which once stable neighborhoods felt transient and people ceased to care about their community. Black residents also frequently depicted a sense of being "overwhelmed" by the new housing patterns, citing ideologies of space focused on crowding, as is evident in this conversation between Doreena, Joyce and Tiffany:

Doreena: Right, right because they have 25 people live in one house—and you can't have that many people in the house. My sister say they sleep in shifts [Joyce laughing]

Joyce: They sleep in shifts [laughing]

Doreena: That's what they do, they bring a truckload of people, and then they empty a truckload, and then another truckload is going away, and then they all stay in the one house

Tiffany: Well I'm sure that's like, like a, kind of like a cultural thing, the family kinda stays together, you know what I mean, and I'm sure.

Doreena: I don't know what it is

Tiffany: And it's probably alien to us, just as anything to people outside of us is alien to them, like that we do, like 'I can't believe those—' you know what I mean? That they do that but, I don't know, just overwhelmed

Many times in our conversations with Black community members, they both expressed their sense of being “overwhelmed” by the growth of the Mexican community, while simultaneously attempting to understand Mexicans’ point of view and reduce the social distance between them. Michelle did this earlier when she described how Mexican residents were taken advantage of by landlords. Tiffany also works to develop both an understanding of who these new residents are and how they might be similar to her, when she explains that living together is “kind of like a cultural thing, the family kinda stays together,” and in her acknowledgement that while Mexican practices are “alien to us,” that the practices of her community are probably “alien to them.” We have observed many instances of Black residents tacking between producing a Mexican “other” and then attempting to relate to that “other.” In her individual interview, Joyce compares histories of Black residence in Marshall as people transitioned towards homeownership and the situation for new Mexican arrivals:

I mean we’re, we’re, we’re used to having a lot of families but not quite like they would have a lot of families in their houses. And it just seemed like they were running down the houses. And that’s just because they’re probably poor people coming in to—even though we were poor, we still, we had a little bit of money. It’s like, it’s you just didn’t have enough money to move out of that neighborhood but you had enough money that you weren’t, poor poor. Does that make sense?

In this comparison, Joyce notes that perhaps one of the differences between the experiences of the Black community “before” and the Mexican community now is the extent to which Mexicans moving in are “poor” in ways that are beyond the experience of earlier Black residents who “didn’t have enough money to move out of the neighborhood” but weren’t “poor poor.” Black interlocutors do sometimes “other” Mexican residents. But, similar to White residents, they also describe potential similarities between the two communities, however the domains of these similarities are heterogeneous. While the arrival of Mexicans to the community, precipitated by White flight, marks the disjuncture between the nostalgic time “before” and Marshall now, it is not a simple story of unilateral “othering” whereby Black residents are hosts and Mexicans the immigrant “other.” Due to their own family histories of migration northwards and the struggles associated with achieving economic success, Black residents draw some connections between their own experiences and the experiences of Mexicans in Marshall. While this tendency to connect their own trajectory with that of Mexican arrivals is shared by both Italian and Black residents, the groups imagine different connections with Mexicans. Black community members mostly do not view the Mexican migration as a revitalizing force in Marshall. Instead, many Black residents feel themselves being pushed out of town by the “overwhelming” presence of Mexicans.

4.8. Spatiotemporal exclusion

In addition to changes within their neighborhoods, our Black interlocutors point to an increasing sense of exclusion from the commercial district of Marshall, both of which ultimately precipitate the perception of “Black flight” from the community. Main Street, once home to businesses that catered to Black residents, is now filled with Mexican stores and restaurants, leaving Black residents literally and symbolically excluded, both from the commercial spaces in town and from the narratives anticipating Marshall’s future success. As officer Smith describes:

“I could see more Latinos moving into town. I could see them starting businesses, I could see how the west end of Main Street started churning around where we had you know a majority of businesses they were owned by Americans. And when the Latinos started moving up there and started coming in, it started changing. And if you go up there now you’ll see probably 90% of the businesses up on Main Street are Latinos”

Officer Smith presents the transition of downtown Marshall from predominately “American” owned stores to predominately Latino owned stores. While this construction follows the “host” and “other” divide, the manner in which this shift in commercial space took place allows for a heterogeneous “othering” where Latinos (Mexican residents) may be the non-American “other,” but it is Black residents who become effectively “othered” and often excluded from spaces they traditionally felt comfortable in. Our interlocutors describe how, where they once went to Main Street to shop and socialize, they now “don’t frequent Main street at all”—because it is “not nice anymore,” “very congested” and filled with “babies, and strollers,” and also because they feel distinctly unwelcome in the new Mexican run businesses. John, a community organizer in his late thirties, has dedicated himself to solving the “black and brown problem” in Marshall. John’s mother was born in Marshall, and he moved back to the community as an adult. Despite his desire to bring the Mexican and Black residents of Marshall together, John can relate to the sentiments of other Black community members when they feel excluded from Main Street. John described to us what it is like for him to walk down Main Street:

John: Um, the disrespect was to the utmost, um, when I would go into the stores, there’s a section of Main Street that’s predominantly Mexican, so when I go into the stores, it was very hostile, disrespectful, uh

Interviewer: Towards you?

John: Towards me. Because they saw me as a black man, and it was, it was prevalent.

John goes on to recall a specific experience he had on Main Street in which he encountered two Mexican women and their children:

"As I walked up, and they pulled their child, and looked at me, stared at me, looked me up and down. I was dressed professional, like I was now, I'm pretty clean cut, looked at me as I walked by, looked back at me, continued to speak Spanish. So I remember I looked at them, nod my head, and they pulled her kid and look at me, like offended. And they just kept speaking Spanish and looking at me."

Other Black residents describe how they have been prevented from entering Mexican-owned stores, where in order to shop you have to be buzzed in by store attendants. They describe frustration because stores no longer stock items catering to Blacks or cannot provide assistance in English. Doreena voices her frustration with Spanish-speaking store attendants who are unable to help her:

Doreena: You go in the store, and you ask them a question, and they go

Interviewer: You're shrugging your shoulders—so

Doreena: Why you here? You don't know nothing, you don't go with nothing—why—why you here working? He's just there putting stuff on the shelf but you can't ask him a question 'cause, he go 'Me no understand English.' Why you here working then?

Tiffany: Well—he has to make money as well

Doreena explains that this frustration ultimately led her to stop going to Main Street, a common sentiment among our Black interlocutors, who felt that the Mexican stores did not want them as clientele. In this segment, Doreena is producing an "other" in her use of the third person object plural pronoun "them" to index non-English speaking Mexican workers (Perrino, this Special Issue; Chun, 2004). But Tiffany, her granddaughter, makes a bid to understand the circumstances these workers are facing by reminding Doreena that, "he has to make money as well." The roles assigned to Mexican residents by Black community members are not uniform and uncontested. Sometimes they are the "other" coming in and creating an environment that excludes Black residents from spaces that were once comfortable for them. At other times Black residents align themselves with the struggles of Mexican residents. Black residents position themselves in relation to Mexican residents heterogeneously depending on the context they are speaking about and on generational differences. While our younger Black interlocutors, like Tiffany, tended to frequently draw connections between themselves and Mexican community members, some older Black residents did as well, especially when connecting with the struggle Mexican residents are going through.

Black residents' accounts of community decline differ from those of White residents. Even after the malls opened, our Black interlocutors claim that the commercial areas of Main Street still catered to their needs and that their community was intact and thriving. As Tiffany mentioned earlier, her hairdresser used to be there, as did other stores and restaurants targeting Black consumers. For our Black interlocutors, decline resulted from White flight and the corresponding shift from owner occupied properties to rental properties, which then allowed for the arrival of Mexican "others." With Mexican migration came shifts in historically Black neighborhoods and the closure of Black businesses along Main Street. The changes White residents describe as "revitalizing" Marshall, like the opening of Mexican businesses, are viewed by Black interlocutors as symptoms of community decline and instability. Thus Whites and Blacks diverge in how they represent Marshall's past and its likely future trajectory.

4.9. Black flight

Among White residents, a narrative of community renewal and revitalization has emerged in response to Mexican migration. But a very different narrative emerges among long term Black residents. As a result of shifts in the composition of people in their neighborhood and feelings of exclusion from downtown Marshall, long term Black residents describe a trend of "Black flight" from Marshall. Our interlocutors expressed the sense Black residents have of being "pushed out," and they frequently compare their experiences with Mexican arrival to those of White families after an influx of Black residents in the 1960s. As Joyce explains, "the White people probably felt like when the Black people came in ... I think we're feeling that same experience where the Spanish people feel like, it feels like they're pushing us out." Harrison makes a similar comparison when he describes the trajectory of the town's racial history:

"I was sayin' it's funny because, you talking about in the 60s and 70s most of Marshall was Caucasian, and then you know, 80s, 90s, that's when the more African Americans came and the Caucasians started moving out to East Marshall and West Marshall, and there was more of us than anything, and now the Latinos came and the African Americans are moving out and it's more of them."

Repeatedly, our Black interlocutors characterized Marshall as no longer having "a lot of African Americans anymore" because the "Spanish people have moved in" and Black people "moved out." This characterization of Black flight is not evident in the most recent census numbers, which actually show an increase in Black residents. But Black flight is a reality for the longstanding Black residents we spoke with. Doreena, who is herself an example of Black flight, noted that there are "not many Black people there no more on the east end" and explained that she moved out of downtown to East Marshall because of the way her neighborhood was changing. She recently went back to her old neighborhood and described the experience as strange because there are "only three families left down there, everybody else they split and gone up other places." Jamar explains a similar sense of dislocation when he drives through town and doesn't see the people he grew up with anymore. He explains Black flight this way:

"The thing is the same thing like when Black people came in and White people were like 'what are you doing here?' same thing with the Mexicans, we kinda lookin' at them being like, 'well what are you doing here?' and I think that's just more so, it's a like a domino effect, and I think that's just more so, that's what's happening. I mean, I don't even want to call it human, but I guess you would say that because you're not used to it because you're just something totally different, so when it changes, a lot of people don't change with it, they don't want to change they don't accept it, and they just like, 'you know what, whatever, I'm leaving, I'm moving, I'm out because I can't take all these Mexicans here anymore, all these stores are Mexican, everything is Mexican. I'm leaving' and it's that frustration, and it's like, I'm done, they took over everything. And I think that's what's happened.

In his characterization of the Black community members who leave, Jamar describes the similarities between White flight and Black flight in Marshall, and the frustrations felt by Black residents who see spaces that once catered to them now owned and occupied by Mexicans, that "everything is Mexican." Michelle, who lives on the north side of Marshall, explained that she moved to her current house because she "always thought it was a very nice neighborhood," she described it as "quiet" and as a "nice place" to raise her daughter. However she notices that the neighborhood is changing and Mexican families are moving in nearby. "I like it," Michelle told us, "but, I'm ready to go." Whether or not Michelle does ultimately leave Marshall, noting that she is "ready to go" indicates that she does not see a place for her, nor her daughter, in Marshall's future.

As we have demonstrated, our Black interlocutors narrate a future trajectory of Marshall in which the longstanding Black residents who have generational history in the community have left. Theirs is not a story of revitalization, but of displacement, told through spatiotemporal accounts of the community juxtaposing Marshall before and after the arrival of Mexican immigrants.

5. Conclusions

In Marshall, significant "othering" occurs, but it is not simply a situation in which longstanding residents "other" immigrants. Instead, "othering" is complex, heterogeneous, and contingent upon how residents understand both the past and future of the community. Diverse histories of immigration, segregation, industrial development and decline inform the ways in which residents position Mexican immigrants as either helping to revitalize the community, or fragmenting it and causing dislocation. As we have demonstrated in this article, in their narratives, Marshall residents often focus on the use of spatial and temporal scales in their stories about the transformation of the town.

For White residents, Mexican immigrants bring revitalization to the community after years of economic decline. This formulation is framed by how White residents imagine the town's past, and how they position various social actors in that past. Mexicans are characterized as embodying the traits of European immigrants who preceded them—hard working, family oriented and industrious. Mexicans bring a renewal of past success in Marshall, and are contrasted to negative portrayals of Black residents. While the White residents often compared their own history with that of Mexican immigrants, they never made similar comparisons with the history of Black residents in the community, despite many characteristics they might have in common. Through their narratives, White residents "other" the longstanding Black community while reducing social distance between themselves and Mexican immigrants.

Our Black interlocutors characterize both the town's history and the future trajectory of Marshall differently, however. While both communities construct a time "before" that was filled with nostalgia (Cavanaugh, 2004), for Black interlocutors Marshall was a town that offered strong social bonds, a "small town feel," and commercial areas catering specifically to Black residents. This sense of community changed not with the economic decline of the 1960s, but with the arrival of Mexican residents in the 1990s. Black residents feel "othered" by Mexican immigrants in addition to "othering" them—because they feel that their businesses and neighborhoods have been taken over by this new population. Nonetheless, in addition to "othering" and being "othered," Black residents also expressed feelings of allegiance with Mexican residents—not for their perceived personality traits, but for their experiences of struggle and will to survive. This ambivalent relationship produces a situation in which Black residents compare their own experiences both with White flight and with Mexican immigrant struggles. Unlike White residents who viewed Marshall before the arrival of Mexicans as a "scary place," Marshall offered our Black interlocutors both community and stability. Instead of the revitalization described by Whites, for Black residents the arrival of Mexican immigrants precipitated the dissolution of longstanding neighborhoods and Black flight out of town.

The racial position of the speaker influences both the key historical moments and the evidence provided for Marshall's economic decline. Our interlocutors use divergent resources to heterogeneously explain Marshall's history, as residents from different racial groups explain the nature and direction of community change in notably different ways. The two concurrent narratives of revitalization and Black flight reflect the discursive struggles that surround incidents of migration in which "hosts" and "others" are not determined simply based on country of origin, but are instead produced in relation to social and economic histories in the community. "Othering" in this context is not simple or unidirectional—longstanding Black residents who might be considered "hosts" to the new immigrants find themselves in positions of "othering," of being "othered" and also, at times, allied with the Mexican population. Both White and Black residents heterogeneously align themselves with Mexican community members, but these alignments occur within different domains. The positioning of "self" and "other" inform how our interlocutors perceive Marshall's historical and future trajectories, and depend upon the spatiotemporal scales deployed to narrate their experiences.

Acknowledgements

We would like to thank Katie Clonan-Roy, Cate Rhodes, and the rest of our research team at Penn GSE for their extensive ethnographic research, which provided much of the empirical data for this article. Additionally, we want to thank our interlocutors in Marshall for being so incredibly generous with their time.

Appendix

Transcription Conventions: For the purposes of this paper our interview segments are being used as part of an ethnographic analysis. As a result, we are using only basic transcription conventions.

Italics within dialog are used for emphasis.

— Following an utterance indicates a pause.

" are used when the speaker voices someone other than themselves within a quote.

"" are used to denote quotations from a single speaker.

Fillers have been deleted from interview segments to improve readability and comprehension.

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